

CASE ID: 201512710002

EPISODE NAME: US Taiwan Arms Sales 2015

2015/12/17 - Ongoing

Sender: China (710)

Target: United States (2)

Issue: End Weapons/Materials Proliferation (9)

Final Outcome: Stalemate in the Threat Stage (4)

Summary:

In response to a 2015/12/15 \$1.83 billion USD arms sale to Taiwan by the US, China threatened to impose sanctions on the involved US defense companies on 2015/12/17. China did not impose sanctions.

Narrative:

On 2015/12/17, China threatened to impose sanctions against the American defense companies involved in a United States arms sale to Taiwan, in an attempt to stop the US from arming the island's government.¹ China considers Taiwan to be part of its territory. China had previously threatened sanctions against US companies for arms sales to Taiwan during Obama's first term.²

These sanctions were in response to the Obama administration's 2015/12/15 notification to Congress of a \$1.83 billion USD arms sale package for Taiwan, including frigates, anti-tank missiles, amphibious assault vehicles and other equipment.³ On 2015/12/17, the Chinese Vice Foreign Minister Zheng Zeguang summoned the US envoy Kaye Lee and issued a vague and weakly-committed threat of import restrictions on the companies involved in the sale, saying, "Taiwan is an inalienable part of China's territory. China strongly opposes the U.S. arms sale to Taiwan."⁴

China never followed through with their threat of these specific sanctions against the US defense companies.⁵ However, later arms sales did produce retaliation, and these sanctions are still in effect.⁶

¹ "China Warns Against First Major US-Taiwan Arms Sale in Four Years." *The Guardian*, December 16th, 2015.

www.theguardian.com/us-news/2015/dec/16/china-warns-against-us-taiwan-arms-sale-defence.

² Bradsher, Keith. "U.S. Deal with Taiwan Has China Retaliating." *The New York Times*, January 30th, 2010, www.nytimes.com/2010/01/31/world/asia/31china.html.

³ Brunnstrom, David, and Zengerle, Patricia. "Obama Administration Authorizes \$1.83-bln Arms Sale to Taiwan." *Reuters*, December 17th, 2015.

www.reuters.com/article/us-usa-taiwan-arms/obama-administration-authorizes-1-83-billion-arms-sale-to-taiwan-idUSKBN0TZ2C520151217.

⁴ "China Summons U.S. Envoy to Protest U.S. Authorization of Taiwan Arms Sales." *Reuters*, December 16th, 2015. <https://www.reuters.com/article/idUSKBN0TZ2WX/>.

⁵ Tiezzi, Shannon. "On Taiwan Arms Sales, China's Bark May Be Worse than Its Bite." *The Diplomat*, December 18th, 2015.

thediplomat.com/2015/12/on-taiwan-arms-sales-chinas-bark-may-be-worse-than-its-bite/.

⁶ "Decision on Taking Countermeasures Against U.S. Military Companies and Senior Executives." *The Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China*, 10 October 2024,

